Introductory Note

1. Ms. Aisshwarya DKS Hegde, National Education Foundation, Bengaluru

Ms. Aisshwarya DKS Hegde is Trustee Secretary of the National Education Foundation (NEF), Bengaluru. NEF runs the Global Academy of Technology (GAT), an autonomous engineering and management college affiliated to VTU, as well as National Hill View Public School and the Global College of Nursing. A management graduate, she oversees the academic and administrative work of these institutions and speaks regularly to students on preparation, perseverance and the value of education. The Foundation has an established record of mentoring Government schools.

2. Little Rock Indian School (LRIS), Brahmavar, Udupi

Little Rock Indian School is a co-educational, CBSE-affiliated day-cum-boarding school in Brahmavar, Udupi district. It was founded in 1982 by the late Dr. C.T. Abraham. The school stands on a 30-acre campus in Chanthar Village, about 72 km north of Mangaluru, and has more than 3,450 students and about 175 teachers. IIRF ranks it fourteenth among schools in India, in recognition of its consistent Class 12 Board results, qualified management and faculty, teaching methods, extra-curricular activities, infrastructure, digital learning and care of students.

3. B.M. Patil Public School, BLDE Association, North Karnataka

The BLDE Association serves communities across North Karnataka through more than 75 educational and healthcare institutions.

- **Healthcare.** Its Sri B.M. Patil Medical College Hospital provides free or heavily subsidised treatment, diagnostic camps and surgery to rural, low-income families.
- **Student service.** Students organise blood donation drives and food distribution campaigns such as “Ek Mutthi Anj”.
- **Agriculture.** The Centre of Excellence for Rural Rejuvenation offers local farmers technical support, agricultural guidance and training in organic farming.
- **Environment.** Its campuses use rainwater harvesting, solar and wind power, and organic composting. The “One Student, One Tree” drive has planted thousands of trees to counter the region’s aridity.
- **Skills and employment.** A partnership with Toyota Kirloskar Motor has set up an automotive centre of excellence to build technical skills and improve employability. Collaborations with HDFC Bank and BharatCares provide livelihood and skill-development training for rural youth.
- **Education and awareness.** The Association runs many rural schools and colleges with highly concessional fees for first-generation learners, and conducts public awareness campaigns on voter participation, electrical safety and cyber security.

4. Bangalore Salesian Society (Don Bosco), Bengaluru

The Bangalore Salesian Society, with its head office in Bengaluru, works for the empowerment of weaker sections of society in 22 of Karnataka’s 31 districts. Under the Society, Don Bosco Yadgiri, an NGO, has worked in Yadgir district for more than 25 years. Its work includes support for children from poor families, the empowerment of women through Self-Help Groups, awareness programmes and tuition centres. Its current MINDS programme supports child welfare through counselling. The Society also runs a school, a degree college and a hostel for students from poor families. These programmes have reached thousands of children, women and young people in the district.